

OPEN TO THE FAITHFUL
The 14th century Mishkal mosque in Kozhikode

INDIA PICTURE

THE LAND OF LEGENDS

It's a warm, sticky June morning, and I am on the hunt for some of those stories with Rajeesh Raghavan, a travel professional and local-history expert, who is guiding me through Kozhikode. Within minutes into our half-hour drive to the city, he recounts tales from Kozhikode's long and complex past. Along the way, he points to landmarks that reflect its continued presence—a century-old British-built iron bridge still in daily use; the Commonwealth Tile Factory in Feroke, built in 1864, and still operating; the Wadiaji Parsi Anjuman Baug, an 18th-century fire temple, managed and maintained by the Marshalls, a four-member family that is all that remains of Kozhikode's once significant Parsi community.

Two centuries before their arrival, Vasco da Gama reached India by sea in 1498 and opened up trade with Europe, bypassing overland Arab routes. His landing point on Kappad beach, 30 minutes away, is a popular tourist spot. The Portuguese explorer was warmly welcomed by the Zamorins, the erstwhile rulers of Kozhikode, whose keen nose for business turned the city into a major spice and silk emporium.

The Zamorin of Calicut once ruled these streets. Today, their palace is a hospital and the throne room a maternity ward, but their impact is still felt, not least in the city's modern marketplaces. Valiyangadi Market, once the bustling heart of the city's spice and grain trade, remains active today with wholesale dealers in rice, areca nut, and coconut oil. Silk Street, and SM Street (Sweet Meat Street), one of the city's oldest commercial roads, are busy retail hubs where traditional halwa stalls sit comfortably beside mobile stores and branded outlets.

I sample a variety of the famous "sweet meat" that gives the street its name at the 92-year-old Shankaran Bakery. "Our halwa is originally an Arabian delicacy," Rajeesh says, as I am handed a slice from the jewel-like, soft, candied bricks made of refined flour, sugar, and oil or ghee. My visit coincides with Eid al-Adha, so the shopping hub is deserted: today is all about prayer, family and feasts. In Kozhikode, faith doesn't stand apart—it leans in, like neighbours over a shared wall. The 600-year-old Thali Temple, the 700-year-old Mishkal Mosque, once charred by the Portuguese in 1510, and then rebuilt, ("with wood from the Zamorin's own fort," Rajeesh notes), and the Mother of God cathedral, built on land gifted by the same Hindu ruler, are all a stone's throw away from each other.

As we head to Paragon, the city's iconic restaurant, known for their impeccable food, Sunday lunch crowds and must-have tender-coconut custard, Rajeesh advises caution: "Famous personalities are snuck in through the back," he says with a smile, "We'll have to wait." Indeed, the place is packed, despite it being a holiday, so we grab our custards and savour spicy prawn fry, Malabar biryani, and a raw mango-and-mint mocktail at Adaminte Chayakada (Adam's Tea Shop). Between bites, Rajeesh tells me about a vegetarian crocodile named Babiya in Kasaragod who, until his recent demise, lived in a temple pond and ate *prasadam*. You just can't make this up. But in "city of truth" Kozhikode, you don't have to.



Ayurveda health and wellness centre, cooking classes (charges apply), visits to experience Theyyam performances

The trip logistics were handled by Discovery Journeys India, who have been offering tailormade holidays in India for over 30 years

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